

GREAT WRITERS IN BRITISH HISTORY

The UK has a prestigious literary history and tradition. Several British writers, including the novelist Sir William Golding, the poet Seamus Heaney, and the playwright Harold Pinter, have won the Nobel Prize in Literature. Other authors have become well known in popular fiction.

Life in the UK – a guide for new residents features a number of important writers from the UK's literary history. Here's some of the names you should know:



THE MIDDLE AGES



Geoffrey Chaucer (1342/43–1400)

In the years leading up to 1400, Chaucer wrote a series of poems in English about a group of people going to Canterbury on a pilgrimage. The people decided to tell each other stories on the journey, and the poems describe the travellers and some of the stories they told. This collection of poems is called *The Canterbury Tales*.



ELIZABETHAN PERIOD



William Shakespeare (1564–1616)

Shakespeare was born in Stratford-upon-Avon, England. He was a playwright and actor and wrote many poems and plays. His most famous plays include *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, *Hamlet*, *Macbeth* and *Romeo and Juliet*.

Shakespeare had a great influence on the English language and invented many words that are still common today.



GEORGIAN PERIOD



Jane Austen (1775–1817)

Austen was an English novelist. Her books include *Pride and Prejudice* and *Sense and Sensibility*. Her novels are concerned with marriage and family relationships. Many have been made into television programmes or films.



VICTORIAN PERIOD



Charles Dickens (1812–70)

Dickens wrote a number of very famous novels, including *Oliver Twist* and *Great Expectations*. You will hear references in everyday talk to some of the characters in his books, such as Scrooge (a mean person) or Mr Micawber (always hopeful).

Thomas Hardy (1840–1928)

Hardy was an author and poet. His best-known novels focus on rural society and include *Far from the Madding Crowd* and *Jude the Obscure*.

Sir Arthur Conan Doyle (1859–1930)

Doyle was a Scottish doctor and writer. He was best known for his stories about Sherlock Holmes, who was one of the first fictional detectives.



MODERN WRITERS



Evelyn Waugh (1903–66)

Waugh wrote satirical novels, including *Decline and Fall* and *Scoop*. He is perhaps best known for *Brideshead Revisited*.

Sir Kingsley Amis (1922–95)

Amis was an English novelist and poet. He wrote more than 20 novels. The most well known is *Lucky Jim*.

Graham Greene (1904–91)

Greene wrote novels often influenced by his religious beliefs, including *The Heart of the Matter*, *The Honorary Consul*, *Brighton Rock* and *Our Man in Havana*.

J K Rowling (1965–)

Rowling wrote the *Harry Potter* series of children's books, which have enjoyed huge international success. She now writes fiction for adults as well.



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